PROFILE

FROM SHADOWS TO SPOTLIGHT

An unassuming BJP loyalist, Nayab Singh Saini has defied expectations to secure a historic win in Haryana

IN A STUNNING POLITICAL OUTCOME, Nayab Singh Saini, once dismissed as a lightweight protégé of former chief minister Manohar Lal Khattar, has emerged as Haryana's unexpected victor. Leading the BJP to its best-ever assembly performance with 48 seats and a 39.94 per cent vote share, Saini has not only neutralised a decade of potential anti-incumbency but also etched his name among the select few chief ministers who have successfully defended their mandate in the state.

Handpicked by Khattar—then an RSS *pracharak*—as a docile *swayamsevak* in the late '80s, Saini had moved to the BJP along with him in 1994. Since then, his rise through the party ranks was steady but unremarkable. So much so that, when he was appointed as the BJP's Haryana unit chief in October last year, hardly anyone outside the party's inner circles had heard much about him even though he was the sitting Kurukshetra MP. Just six months later, when the BJP central leadership decided to pull Khattar into national politics, the state's reins were handed over to his favourite disciple. With just weeks to go for the Lok Sabha election and the assembly polls scheduled later in the year, the party hoped that Saini—an OBC—would be able to rally rural non-Jat communities against the Bhupinder Singh Hooda-led Congress's Jat consolidation. But many within the party viewed the mild-mannered Saini, who was hardly a community leader, as a potential scapegoat for an anticipated electoral defeat.

However, the 54-year-old leader—who first entered the Haryana assembly just a decade ago—confounded critics by spearheading a campaign that resonated with voters across the state. Unlike his mentor, known for his rigid ideas and bureaucratic approach, Saini's willingness to listen and engage, his ability to crack jokes and maintain a smiling demeanour won him supporters both within and outside the party. Presenting himself as an agent of change, Saini addressed 90 rallies, striking a chord with various social groups that helped the BJP secure 22 seats it had never won before. More importantly, he allowed the local Sangh and the BJP's national leadership take over the organisational work, a synergy that helped the party overcome anti-incumbency sentiments.

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As he now prepares to take oath for a second time, Saini has his task cut out for him. Haryana remains revenue-deficient, with a projected deficit of Rs 17,817 crore (1.5 per cent of the GSDP) for FY25. Saini's promises of subsidised cooking gas, financial aid for women and government jobs for youth will further strain the exchequer. He also has to navigate the complex social dynamics of Haryana, particularly the alienation of the Jat community—a challenge his predecessor failed to overcome. As he steps out of Khattar's shadow, Saini's political acumen will be put to the test. ■

—Anilesh S. Mahajan



RAJWANT RAWAT